

5, The Geographical Openness of the Islamic World Was Detrimental to Its Development

Ironically and rather dramatically, although the Islamic world's frequent interactions with neighboring ethnic groups exerted a definite negative impact on the development of Islamic society, the "responses" to this expansion serve as absolutely excellent subjects for researching how societies at different developmental stages react when confronted with the exact same ideology (*especially the ideology of the **feudal period** /封建时期*).

This is because, prior to the Age of Discovery, Christian Europe was situated relatively on the periphery of the world and did not face the immensely complex and volatile external conditions that the Islamic world endured. By the time Europeans began reversing the global paradigm through the Age of Discovery and expanding toward every corner of the globe, their overwhelming military superiority had already become glaringly obvious, and they had long since departed from the phase of a typical **feudal society** (封建社会). (*This implies that Christianity itself was no longer a typical **feudal religion** /封建时期*).

This dynamic bears a striking resemblance to the history of China. In my view, although the historical trajectory of our country can thoroughly be characterized as a rare, monumental tragedy, it is precisely these narratives of societies marching toward failure—like the Chinese and Islamic societies—that can effectively explain why the West and Japan ultimately succeeded!

Just as I observed when analyzing Japan's learning from China during the Asuka and Nara periods: when a society is confronted with a myriad of foreign imports—including artifacts, ideology, culture, and institutions—what it ultimately manages to absorb and integrate into its own entity will **inevitably be the contents that align with its current stage of social development!**

I previously pointed out that Islam possessed an overwhelming superiority over **pre-feudal societies** (前封建社会). However, it was equally impossible for the Islam that conquered these **pre-feudal** regions not to be profoundly influenced by the local conditions.

Africa, being the cradle of humanity and the continent with the most staggering diversity, witnessed various distinct models of Islamic expansion. When **pre-state societies** (前国家社会) and **early slavery societies** (奴隶制早期国家)—represented by East and Central Africa—adopted Islam, they retained a massive volume of clan-society vestiges. This included practices like idolatry and matrilineal inheritance, customs that Islam conspicuously and explicitly repudiates.

This occurred simply because these societies were even more backward than the Arab society during the Prophet's lifetime; they fundamentally had not yet reached the social stage where blood-tie clans begin to disintegrate. Consequently, some appalling primitive customs, such as female genital mutilation (割礼), actually reverse-infiltrated and proliferated within Islam! As to the exact reasons behind this, the reader can naturally deduce.

In the bend of the Niger River in West Africa, the trans-Saharan trade brought astonishing wealth, advanced knowledge, and throngs of visitors from distant lands. Stimulated by external forces starting from the 13th century, this region was able to form massive empires with **classical characteristics** (古典特征), such as the Mali Empire, relatively early. (*Here, "early" is relative to the actual developmental conditions of the local society, not compared to other global regions*).

The rulers of Mali converted to Islam driven by both external diplomatic interests and internal ruling imperatives. This is a classic textbook example of a **classical state** (古典国家) utilizing Islam as a state religion! One can distinctly observe the characteristics of Islam functioning as a state religion in West Africa back then. For instance, the imperial rulers relied on the mosques in Timbuktu to construct the University of Sankore, the scale and academic caliber of which were sufficient to leave a profound impression on travelers from across the globe. A relaxed social atmosphere and academic prosperity are the absolute hallmarks of a **classical society** (古典社会).

Furthermore, one can notice that straight through the reign of the Songhai Empire (桑海帝国), those who truly practiced Islam remained the imperial royal family and the high aristocracy. The influence of Islam was strictly confined to major cities; it had not spread broadly across the vast rural and pastoral areas.

I note that some scholars have already pointed out that between the 10th and 12th centuries, the Black monarchs and ruling elites across the entire Sahel basically converted to Islam (*provided, of course, that their societies had already entered a state formation; as for the tribes, their beliefs remained highly diverse*). However, the true popularization of Islam at the grassroots level of society was ultimately achieved through the Jihad movements that erupted around 1800!

It is believed that the same holds true within the present-day Republic of Sudan. For a prolonged period, the Funj Sultanate (芬吉苏丹国) was essentially nothing more than an indigenous African regime draped in an Islamic cloak. It was not until the precipice of its collapse that Islamic law finally penetrated deeply into society.

Following the disintegration of the Songhai Empire, the trans-Saharan trade subsequently plunged into decline. By this time, the socio-economic conditions necessary to sustain a **classical state** had already vanished, leaving the magnificent mosques and universities desolate.

However, with the deepening activities of Sufi **religious orders** (教团) in West Africa and the gradual maturation of the conditions for **feudalization** (封建化) in the Sahel region, two centuries later in the 18th century, Islam experienced a second wave of propagation locally.

This wave of propagation was undoubtedly accomplished through multiple holy wars spearheaded by the Fulani people, spanning 3,500 kilometers from the Atlantic Ocean to Central Africa. Islam was thus able to firmly take root across the entire Sahel region!

The radical, xenophobic, and fundamentalist Islam was merely the surface phenomenon; what lay behind it was the pragmatic necessity of the Fulani nation, acting as a **feudal ruling class**, to conquer and govern vast territories.

Therefore, one can see with absolute clarity: **Islam was always able to effortlessly conquer regions more backward than itself** (*this is because, as we previously established, Islam is a religion suited for early feudal societies, hence anything "more backward" constitutes a pre-feudal society*), **but when facing regions that had already been feudalized, it was utterly powerless!** Even brief occupations would ultimately be repelled.

(*Even if Islam was introduced or even won the conversion of rulers while a society was still in a pre-feudal stage, realizing a Sharia-compliant Islamic social formation still strictly required the emergence of feudal characteristics within that region*).

Naturally, people cannot overly criticize the latter point, because the backward conquering the advanced is inherently a relatively rare occurrence.

However, the former characteristic is simply far too glaring! **This resulted in Islam finding it exceedingly difficult to accept the ideologies and cultures of advanced regions, yet frequently falling victim to the corrosive influence of regions more backward than itself.**

The expansion of Islam might indeed be a breathtaking enterprise of conquest. But for the ordinary Muslim commoners who practice the faith, did they ultimately benefit from this expansion, or, looking at the long arc of history, did they actually fall victim to it?

5，伊斯兰世界地理上的开放性对其发展并非有利

颇具戏剧性的是，伊斯兰世界在其邻近族群频繁的互动虽然对于伊斯兰社会的发展起到了一定负面作用，但是这种扩张的“回应”的确是人们研究不同阶段社会在面临同一种思想（尤其是封建时期的意识形态）时所做不同表现的极佳对象。这是因为在地理大发现之前，基督教的欧洲相对地处于世界的边缘，并没有像伊斯兰世界这样面对如此复杂多变的外部情况，而等到欧洲人开始通过地理大发现扭转世界格局，向全世界各个地区扩张时，他们在武力上的优势已经变得十分显著，而且已经离开典型的封建社会这一阶段了（这意味着基督教也不再是典型的封建宗教）。这一点跟中国的历史颇为相似，在我看来我国的历史进程虽然足以称得上是罕见的悲剧，但是恰恰是像中国社会和伊斯兰社会这样走向失败的故事，才能够解释为什么西方和日本能够成功。正如我在观察飞鸟奈良时代的日本向中国学习的时候所注意到的事，当一个社会面临形形色色的舶来品，包括器物、思想文化和制度等等，它最终能够吸收并化为自身一部分的必然是符合其当下社会发展阶段的内容。

之前已指出伊斯兰教对于前封建社会具有压倒性的优越性，但是征服这些前封建地区的伊斯兰教也不可能不受到当地的影响。非洲作为人类起源地，多样性最为显著的大洲，伊斯兰教在这里的扩张呈现出了不同的模式。以东非、中非为代表的前国家社会和早期奴隶制社会在接纳伊斯兰教的时候保持了大量氏族社会的遗存，包括偶像崇拜，母系继承这样伊斯兰教明显不认同的习俗，这是因为这些社会甚至比先知生活时期的阿拉伯社会更加落后，他们原本也并没有发展到血缘氏族瓦解的社会阶段。一些现在看来极为严重的陋习，例如割礼竟然反过头来在伊斯兰教中传播，至于其原因读者自然能够想通。在西非尼日尔河的河曲地区，跨撒哈拉贸易带来了惊人的财富，先进的知识和大量远方的来客，从13世纪开始这里在外界刺激下能够较早（是相对于当地社会发展实情的早，而不是与其他地方相比的早）形成马里帝国这样具有古典特征的大帝国。马里的统治者出于对外利益和对内统治的目的皈依伊斯兰教，这是古典国家将伊斯兰教作为国家宗教进行利用的经典事例。人们能够显然地看到伊斯兰教在当年西非作为国家宗教的特征，例如帝国统治者在廷巴克图依托清真寺修建了桑科雷大学，其规模和水准在当年足以让世界各地的旅行者印象深刻，而社会氛围宽松和学术繁荣就是古典社会的典型特征。另外人们也能够注意到一直到桑海帝国（Songhai）统治时期，真正信仰伊斯兰教的仍然是帝国皇室及高级贵族，伊斯兰教的影响局限于大城市，在广大农村和牧区并未广泛传播。我注意到已经有学者指出在10世纪至12世纪整个萨赫勒带的黑人君主以及统治精英（当然，前提是已经进入国家形态的社会，至于部落的信仰依然是多样的）基本上都皈依了伊斯兰教，但是伊斯兰教在社会基层的普及是通过1800年前后发生的圣战运动最终实现的。据信现在的苏丹共和国境内也是如此，芬吉（Fung）苏丹国在很长时间内不过是披着伊斯兰教外衣的非洲本土政权罢了，直到快灭亡的时候伊斯兰教法才变得深入社会。

在桑海帝国瓦解之后，跨撒哈拉贸易随之陷入衰退，此时维系古典国家的社会经济条件已然不存在，宏伟的清真寺和大学变得寂寥。然而随着苏菲教团深入西非的活动以及萨赫勒地区封建化条件的逐渐成熟，到了两个世纪后的18世纪，伊斯兰教在当地经历了第二轮传播。这一轮传播毫无疑问是通过以富拉尼人

为首的，从大西洋到中非跨度七千里的多次圣战完成的，伊斯兰教得以在整个萨赫勒地区牢牢地扎根。激进的，排外的，原教旨主义的伊斯兰教只是表象，其背后是富拉尼民族作为封建统治阶级征服并统治广大领地的实际需要。因此人们可以非常清楚地看到，伊斯兰教总是能够轻而易举地征服比自己更加落后的地区（这是因为我们之前认为伊斯兰教是一种适合早期封建社会的宗教，因此比它更为落后就是前封建社会），但是面对已经封建化的地区却全然无可奈何，即使是短暂占领也会被最后击退（就算伊斯兰教在一个社会仍处于前封建阶段的时候就已经传入甚至赢得了统治者的皈依，符合教法的伊斯兰社会形态仍然需要到该地出现封建化特征才是可能的）。对于后一点人们当然没有什么好责怪的，因为落后征服先进本来就是相对罕见的事，然而前一点特征实在是太过明显。这就导致伊斯兰教不容易接受先进地区的思想文化，但是却频繁地受到比自己更为落后地区的影响。伊斯兰教的扩张或许是一种令人赞叹的征服事业，但是信仰伊斯兰教的普通穆斯林百姓究竟是从这种扩张中受利，还是从长远上看受害了呢？